



The Personal Statement

The UCAS personal statement changed for 2026 entry: one piece of writing became three questions in three boxes, sharing the same 4,000 characters. It takes five tutor times to get a first draft of all three answers from every student, and these are the sheets they write on.

Before you start. Check the dates on ucas.com, because they move by a day or two each year. For 2027 entry the equal consideration dates are 18:00 on 15 October 2026 for Oxford, Cambridge, medicine, dentistry and veterinary, and 18:00 on 13 January 2027 for the rest. Your school's own deadline will be earlier than both.

Print these

Page	What it is
Page 2	What you have actually got. The evidence grid, filled in before anybody writes a sentence.
Page 3	Question one, with prompts that get an answer to it and a page to draft on.
Page 4	Question two, the same shape.
Page 5	Question three, the same shape.
Page 6	The check sheet, ticked by the student, then a friend, then you.

Five tutor times

Week	What happens
Week 1	The evidence grid on page 2, and nothing in sentences. Two columns: what you did, and what it shows. Most first drafts are weak because the student lists things and never says what they show.
Week 2	Question one, on page 3. Fifteen minutes of writing, then two or three read a sentence out. The prompt that unlocks it is almost always "when did you first know you were interested in this".
Week 3	Question two, on page 4. It is about what studying has given them, not what grades they have. UCAS says plainly that restating grades wastes the space.
Week 4	Question three, on page 5. The hard part is not the experience, it is the last sentence saying why it matters for this course.
Week 5	The check sheet on page 6. They tick their own, then swap and tick a friend's, then it reaches you with two columns already filled.

Worth knowing

- 4,000 characters including spaces across all three, a minimum of 350 in each and no maximum on any one. Roughly 1,400, 1,200 and 1,400 is a place to start, not a rule.
- The three answers are reviewed as one, so the same story told in two boxes reads as one story told twice.

A student not applying to university still needs page two: it is an apprenticeship application, a CV and half an interview. Nobody writes a good personal statement from a blank box; they write it from page two.





What you have actually got

Before anybody writes a sentence. Nothing here is written in prose: the left column is the thing, the right column is what it shows about you. The right column is the one that ends up in the statement.

Where to look	What counts
Reading and listening	A book, an article, a podcast, a documentary, a talk, a blog. Anything nobody set you.
In your subjects	A module that changed your mind, an essay, a project, an EPQ, a competition, a piece of practical work.
Work and volunteering	A job, work experience, shadowing, a placement, virtual work experience, anything unpaid.
Responsibility	Caring for somebody at home, a team, a committee, mentoring a younger student, the shift nobody else wanted.
Everything else	A hobby you are serious about, a trip, a course you took on your own, an instrument, a sport, a language.

Fill this in

What you did	And what it shows about you

If the right-hand column is empty, the thing does not go in the statement yet. That is not a reason to drop it, it is a reason to think about it for another minute.





UCAS asks it like this: "Why do you want to study this course or subject?" Minimum 350 characters. Answer the four below in note form first, then write.

1. When did you first know you were interested in this? Not the tidy version, the actual moment. It is allowed to be small.
2. What have you read, watched or listened to about it that nobody set you? Name it, then say what you took from it.
3. What is the question in this subject you would most like answered? The one that is not on any syllabus.
4. What do you want to be able to do at the end of the course that you cannot do now?

About 1,400 characters, which is roughly 230 words. Nobody gets this right first time and it is not supposed to be right yet.



UCAS asks it like this: "How have your qualifications and studies helped you to prepare for this course or subject?" Minimum 350 characters. Answer the three below in note form first, then write.

1. Which single module, topic or piece of work told you most about what this subject is actually like?
2. What can you do now that you could not do in Year 10? Read a long argument, work with data, defend something out loud.
3. What did you do that was your own idea rather than the course's: an EPQ, a competition, an online course, a piece of reading?

About 1,200 characters, which is roughly 200 words. Do not restate your grades: the provider already has them, and every character spent on them is one you do not have left for the thing they cannot see.



UCAS asks it like this: "What else have you done to prepare outside of education, and why are these experiences useful?" Minimum 350 characters. Answer the three below in note form first, then write.

1. What have you done where somebody was relying on you? Work, a team, a committee, or somebody at home.
2. What did you find harder than you expected, and what did you do about it?
3. Why does any of that matter for this course? That sentence is the answer; the rest is setup for it.

About 1,400 characters, which is roughly 230 words. The experience is the easy half. The sentence saying why it matters here is the half that gets read.



The check sheet

Tick your own column first. Then swap with somebody and tick theirs, in their copy. Then it comes to your tutor with two columns already done, which is the only way a tutor gets through a form of thirty.

What you are checking for	Me	A friend	My tutor
Every single thing I name has a sentence after it saying what it shows.			
Nothing is repeated between the three answers. They are read as one piece.			
The first sentence could not have been written by anybody else applying for this course.			
No clichés. "From a young age." "I have always been passionate about." "Ever since I can remember."			
No quotes from anybody else. It sounds like the person who wrote it.			
Question two says what studying gave me, not what grades I got.			
Question three ends on why it matters for this course.			
Each answer is at least 350 characters, and the three together are no more than 4,000.			
I have read the whole thing out loud and nothing made me stumble.			

The count

Question one	Question two	Question three	Total of 4,000

Two sentences from whoever read it

The best sentence in it is

The one thing to change first is

Written by	Read by	Date

